

Travelling India on a student budget

Twelve pages of the practical things nobody puts on a booking page.

Getting there

Sleeper class trains are the cheapest way to cover long distances and book out 60 days ahead. Tatkal opens at 10:00 for AC and 11:00 for non-AC, one day before travel, and is gone in about ninety seconds.

State transport buses are slower than private operators but run to timetable and cost roughly half. For hill routes, take the day bus — the views are the point and night driving on those roads is not worth the saving.

What a stay actually costs

A clean double room in a small town runs Rs 1,200–2,000. In Goa, Manali or Jaisalmer during December that same room is two to three times more. Homestays are usually cheaper than hotels of the same standard and include breakfast more often than not.

Houseboats and desert camps are priced per boat or per tent, not per person, so they get much cheaper split three or four ways.

Permits and paperwork

Ladakh: Inner Line Permits are needed for Nubra, Pangong and Tso Moriri. Apply online or at the Leh DC office; Indian nationals need a photo ID, foreign nationals need a passport copy.

Northeast: Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland and Mizoram require permits. Meghalaya, Assam and Sikkim do not, except for the high-altitude passes in North Sikkim.

Andaman: no permit for Port Blair, Havelock or Neil. Tribal reserve areas are closed and stay closed.

When to go

The short version: Himalayas from May to September, deserts and plains from November to February, and the coast from October to March. The monsoon between June and September is genuinely spectacular in Meghalaya and Kerala and miserable almost everywhere else.

Region	Best months	Avoid
Goa & Konkan	Nov – Feb	Jun – Aug
Himachal & Ladakh	May – Sep	Dec – Feb
Rajasthan	Oct – Mar	Apr – Jun
Kerala	Sep – Mar	Jun – Aug
Meghalaya	Oct – Apr	Jul – Aug
Andaman	Oct – May	Jun – Sep

One backpack

Forty litres is enough for three weeks anywhere in the country. Two pairs of trousers, four shirts, a fleece, a rain shell, and one pair of shoes you can walk fifteen kilometres in.

Things people forget and then buy at four times the price: a universal sink plug, a headtorch, oral rehydration salts, a padlock for hostel lockers, and a plug adaptor if any of your chargers are not Indian.

Money

UPI works almost everywhere including roadside stalls, but it needs an Indian bank account. Carry Rs 2,000–3,000 in cash for anywhere above 2,500 metres, where networks drop out for hours at a time.

ATMs in small hill towns run dry over long weekends. Withdraw in the last big town before you go up.

Booking with us

Prices on Yatra Kosh are the property rate before GST. There is no booking fee and no paid placement in the listings. Free cancellation applies until 72 hours before check-in, except for houseboats and desert camps, which need seven days.

This guide is part of a B.Sc. Data Science mini project on behavioural data analytics and user experience. The properties listed on the site are fictional; the travel advice is not.